

Behavioral & Case Round Prep

Anthropic Solutions Architect / Solutions Engineer

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How to use this document

This is a worksheet, not a script. The STAR stories below have scaffolding but need your real situations. Fill in the blanks the night before the interview, then read them

aloud once. Don't memorize them word-for-word, you'll sound rehearsed. Memorize the shape and three or four details, then let the language be fresh in the room.

Anthropic's behavioral signal is specific: they want evidence that you can hold a strong opinion without being rigid, tell the truth when it's uncomfortable, and think in systems instead of anecdotes. Every story should earn at least one of those three.

The round usually includes three artifacts:

1. A 90-second bio / "why Anthropic" answer
2. Six to eight STAR stories ready to deploy
3. Three thoughtful questions you ask them

This doc covers all three.

Part 1: The 90-second bio

Opening frame

Don't lead with your résumé. Lead with the thread that connects your past to this job. A simple shape that works:

"I've spent the last [X] years doing [Y]. The thread through all of it has been [Z]. Anthropic is the first place I've found where [Z] is the actual job, not the side quest."

Draft (fill in)

One sentence on where you are now: *[e.g., "I'm a solutions engineer at ___, helping ___ customers deploy ___."]*

One sentence on the thread: *[What's the theme across your career? Examples: helping technical buyers trust new tools; sitting between engineering and sales; translating ambiguity into a plan.]*

One sentence on why Anthropic, specifically: *[Not "because AI is interesting." Something like: "because a regulated enterprise customer deserves someone who can actually explain the safety posture, not just quote the trust center."]*

One sentence on why SA, specifically (vs SE, vs AE, vs engineering): *[SA is the role where technical depth and customer empathy both matter. Name the tradeoff you want.]*

One sentence to close — what you want to be doing in 18 months: *[e.g., "Running the technical side of ten Fortune 500 accounts, with a playbook the next five SAs can use."]*

Delivery notes

Say it at 140 words per minute, not 180. Pause after "the thread through all of it has been ___." Let them hear you think.

Don't apologize for anything in your background. If you're switching domains (e.g., from IC engineer to customer-facing), name it as a deliberate move, not a pivot forced on you.

Part 2: The STAR bank

Eight stories, one per archetype. Each has:

- **Prompt variants** — the different ways an interviewer will ask
- **S/T** — situation and task (what was going on)
- **A** — the action you took (this is the longest section; be specific)
- **R** — the result (quantify when you can)
- **Anthropic angle** — the single sentence you add at the end to connect to the role

For each story, aim for 90 seconds spoken. Two and a half minutes is the max; anything longer and you'll lose them.

Story 1: Ambiguous customer problem

Prompts: "Tell me about a time a customer asked for X when they actually needed Y." / "How do you handle vague requirements?" / "Walk me through a discovery you were proud of."

Situation / Task: *[What did the customer say they wanted? What did you suspect was actually going on?]*

Action:

- The questions you asked that reframed it
- Who you pulled in (PM, eng, their IT, their compliance)
- The moment you realized you were right about the real problem
- How you delivered that news without making them feel dumb

Result:

- What they actually bought / built / chose
- The metric that moved (deal size, time-to-value, retention)
- How the relationship changed afterward

Anthropic angle: *"Discovery is the part of the SA job I care most about, because for enterprise AI, the buyer's stated problem is almost never the real one."*

Story 2: Technical disagreement with a customer

Prompts: "Tell me about a time a customer was wrong." / "How do you push back on a bad idea?" / "When have you held your ground on a technical decision?"

Situation / Task: *[What did the customer insist on? Why was it wrong?]*

Action:

- How you made sure you actually were right (checked assumptions, pulled in a specialist)
- How you raised it (setting, stakeholders, tone)
- The evidence you brought — data, diagram, reproduction
- What you offered as an alternative
- How you handled it if they still disagreed

Result:

- What happened
- If they went with your view: what it saved them
- If they went with theirs: what you did next, what broke, how you recovered the relationship

Anthropic angle: *“Candor is more loyal than deference. A customer paying six figures deserves my real opinion, not the one that keeps the meeting comfortable.”*

Story 3: Losing a deal

Prompts: “Tell me about a deal you lost.” / “A time something didn’t work.” / “When have you been most wrong?”

Situation / Task: *[What was the opportunity? Why did it matter? What went wrong?]*

Action:

- The moment you first noticed it was slipping
- What you tried
- The honest mistake (be specific — “I under-invested in the security conversation” beats “I wish I’d done more”)
- How you ran the loss review

Result:

- Who won, and why
- What you changed about your playbook afterward
- Whether you eventually came back to that account

Anthropic angle: *“Losing well is its own skill. The next five deals at that account depend on how you handle the first loss.”*

Story 4: Shipping under pressure

Prompts: “Tell me about a high-pressure delivery.” / “A time you had to move fast.” / “When have you had to ship something imperfect?”

Situation / Task: *[What was the deadline? What happened to compress it?]*

Action:

- How you scoped what had to ship vs. what could wait
- Who you told, and when

- The tradeoff you explicitly accepted (this is the key part, name the thing you let slip on purpose)
- How you protected the team from panic

Result:

- Did you hit the date
- What broke later because of the tradeoff
- What you'd do differently

Anthropic angle: *"The first enterprise deploy of Claude Code will be this kind of moment for some customer. I want to be the SA who already has the muscle."*

Story 5: Coaching someone junior

Prompts: "How do you develop the people around you?" / "A time you helped a teammate grow." / "When have you delegated something hard?"

Situation / Task: *[Who was the person? What were they stuck on?]*

Action:

- What you noticed before they asked for help
- How you gave them the problem without solving it for them
- A specific piece of feedback you gave that was hard to say
- How you adjusted when the first approach didn't work

Result:

- Where they are now
- What they'd tell you was the turning point
- What you learned about your own management style

Anthropic angle: *"If SA hiring keeps pace with Anthropic's growth, every SA is a teacher within a year. I want to be deliberate about it, not accidental."*

Story 6: Saying no to a customer

Prompts: "When have you told a customer no?" / "How do you handle a request that's a bad idea?" / "A time you protected your product from a customer."

Situation / Task: *[What did they ask for? Why was it wrong for them, or for the product?]*

Action:

- How you made sure you weren't just being lazy or defensive
- The conversation, not the email (this matters)
- What you offered instead
- How you escalated when they pushed back

Result:

- What they chose
- How the relationship held
- Whether the broader product benefited from the no

Anthropic angle: *“Every ‘yes’ to a bad idea becomes a roadmap item someone has to unwind. Saying no early is a gift to the next SA on the account.”*

Story 7: Cross-functional conflict

Prompts: “A time you had to work with a team that didn’t want to work with you.” / “How do you handle it when eng and sales disagree?” / “When have you brokered a hard decision?”

Situation / Task: *[Which teams? What was the disagreement actually about? What was at stake?]*

Action:

- How you figured out the real conflict (usually isn’t the stated one)
- Who you talked to separately before the joint meeting
- The frame you introduced that made it feel joint instead of zero-sum
- The decision criteria you proposed

Result:

- The call that got made
- How the teams worked together afterward
- Whether you stayed in the middle or stepped out

Anthropic angle: *“SA is the seam between sales and engineering. My job is to make that seam invisible to the customer and productive internally.”*

Story 8: A time you were wrong

Prompts: “When have you been most wrong?” / “Tell me about a belief you changed.” / “What’s something you used to think was true that you no longer believe?”

Situation / Task: *[What did you believe? For how long? What was at stake?]*

Action:

- What the first evidence was that you were wrong (and why you dismissed it)
- The moment you couldn’t dismiss it anymore
- Who you told first
- What you changed, in behavior not in words

Result:

- What got better after you changed your mind

- What you now watch for as an early signal of being wrong about something else

Anthropic angle: *“The AI field moves fast enough that an SA who can’t update their priors is a liability. I’d rather be the one who notices first.”*

Part 3: Questions you ask them

Three questions, one per interviewer if the format is a panel rotation. Mix them by depth, so you don’t come off as one-note. Don’t ask anything you could find on the careers page.

Good question 1 (tactical)

“Walk me through the last technical escalation an SA owned here. Not a success story, just a real one, and what you wish had gone differently.”

Why it works: forces them off rehearsed answers, tells you what real failure looks like at their company, signals you’re thinking about the job as it actually is.

Good question 2 (strategic)

“Claude Code, Claude in Chrome, Claude in Excel, the Agent SDK — from the SA seat, which of these is the one where customer success is hardest to define right now, and why?”

Why it works: shows you’ve done your homework on the product surface, invites them to be honest about messy internals, gives you real information you’ll use if you join.

Good question 3 (personal / cultural)

“What’s something about working here that genuinely surprised you in your first 90 days? Good or bad, just something you didn’t expect.”

Why it works: everyone asks “what’s the culture like?” Nobody asks this. You get the answer you actually wanted.

Question 4 — hold in reserve

“If you had to name the one habit that separates the SAs who thrive here from the ones who plateau, what would it be?”

Use this only if one of the first three doesn’t land, or if you have extra time.

Part 4: The last 48 hours

T-48 hours

- Read this doc once out loud. Time each STAR story. If any is over 2:30 spoken, cut it.
- Pick which four STARs you'll deploy as your "defaults." They should cover: ambiguous customer, technical disagreement, shipping under pressure, a time you were wrong.
- Rehearse the bio three times. Record the third one and listen back.

T-24 hours

- Re-read the job posting. Circle three phrases that show up. Make sure your STAR bank hits each of them at least once.
- Go outside for 45 minutes without your phone.
- No new prep. Don't read new content, don't cram.

T-2 hours

- Eat something with protein.
- Set up the room: lighting, camera height, water nearby, phone on do-not-disturb.
- Pull up the INTERVIEW_PREP one-pager as a safety net, not as a script.
- Run through the bio one more time, conversationally, with no notes.

T-0

- First 20 seconds: breathe, smile, be the calmest person on the call.
 - When you don't know an answer, say so. "Let me think about that for a second" is a complete sentence.
 - Close with your third question, not a thank-you.
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Appendix: Fill-me-in worksheet

Copy this block into a note app. Fill each line with one sentence before the interview.

STORY 1 – Ambiguous customer

Customer: _____
What they said they wanted: _____
What they actually needed: _____
The question that unlocked it: _____
Outcome: _____
Metric: _____

STORY 2 – Technical disagreement

Customer: _____
What they insisted on: _____

Why it was wrong: _____
How you raised it: _____
What happened: _____

STORY 3 – Lost deal

Deal: _____
Why it slipped (your honest mistake): _____
Who won and why: _____
What you changed: _____

STORY 4 – Shipping under pressure

Project: _____
The tradeoff you accepted: _____
Did you hit the date: _____
What broke later: _____

STORY 5 – Coaching

Person: _____
What they were stuck on: _____
Your intervention: _____
Where they are now: _____

STORY 6 – Saying no

Customer: _____
What they asked for: _____
What you offered instead: _____
How the relationship held: _____

STORY 7 – Cross-functional conflict

Teams: _____
Real issue (vs stated): _____
The frame you introduced: _____
The decision: _____

STORY 8 – Being wrong

Belief: _____
First evidence you dismissed: _____
What finally convinced you: _____
What you do differently now: _____

Fill this in, and you're ready.